

A National Food Council (the council) has been established to advise on the development of the strategy. It is a skills-based, multi-disciplinary council comprising members with considerable knowledge and experience from across our food system. It reflects the complexity and interconnectedness of our food system.

The council is chaired by the Secretary of the Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry.

Members were appointed by the Hon Julie Collins MP, Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry.

Communiqués

A communiqué is published after each council meeting.

Membership

Dr Christopher Downs

Dr Chris Downs has more than 30 years' experience as a scientist, innovation leader and executive focussing on the development of crops, foods and beverages that are healthy, safe and sustainable. Chris wants to be known for shaping and improving organisations that support agri-food industry professionals in delivering sustainable nutrition to 10 billion people by 2050.

Chris is the Founding Director of the Food and Beverage Accelerator (FaBA). As a leader at the interface between science and industry, he oversees the development and delivery of innovations that add value to the food and beverage sector and global consumers.

He has been an Executive at the Institute of Crop and Food Research in New Zealand, Leader of Food Innovation at the CSIRO, and General Manager for Crop and Food Science Queensland's Department of Agriculture and Fisheries.

Mel Gatfield

Mel Gatfield is passionate about the people that work in our food system – from the pickers in the field to the waitress in the café. Mel has spent over three decades advocating for working people, driving change, and delivering tangible wins from food production workers to hospitality workers across Australia.

Mel is the Executive Director for Food & Beverages at the United Workers Union (UWU), providing strategic leadership for national campaigns across one of Australia's most essential sectors. Mel also serves as Vice President and NSW Secretary of UWU— representing more than 150,000 members across over 45 industries. She plays a central role in ensuring workers' voices are at the heart of organizational strategy.

Mel serves on the Asia-Pacific Regional Committee of the International Union of Food Workers (IUF), contributing to international solidarity, cross-border organising strategies, and global advocacy on behalf of food and beverage workers.

Simeon Gilding

Since 2019, Simeon has combined farming, consulting and a Senior Fellowship at the Australian Strategic Policy Institute, focusing on technology and national security.

Simeon has served in senior roles across Australia's international relations, defence and intelligence efforts over three decades.

He concluded his public service career as Deputy Director-General at the Australian Signals Directorate, responsible for signals intelligence and cyber operations. Earlier, he served as Defence and Security Adviser in the Prime Minister's Office and as Chief of Staff to the Minister for Defence. In the Department of Defence, he held several leadership roles, including as head of the International Policy Division.

Simeon began his career at the Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade, with postings to Thailand and Myanmar. Later, he led Australia's Consular operations and headed up the Asia, Americas and Trade Branch at the Department of Prime Minister and Cabinet.

Barry Irvin AM

Barry is a sixth-generation dairy farmer who grew up on his family dairy farm in the Bega Valley. Barry's long history with farming includes a strong and practical interest in sustainable agricultural production. Barry has championed a number of environmentally focused projects. Most recently, Barry has led the establishment of a Regional Circularity Co-operative with the ambition of making the Bega Valley the most circular region in the world.

Barry is the Executive Chairman of the Bega Group, which began as a cooperative in a small regional community. It has since grown to become one of Australia's largest dairy and food companies that supplies both the Australian and international markets.

Barry has always believed in giving back to the community and is the long-term Chairman of Giant Steps Australia – an organisation that provides services to children and adults with autism.

Dr Elizabeth Jackson

Dr Elizabeth Jackson has an industry and education background in agribusiness and food supply chain systems with a strong interest in sustainability. She is on the Board of the Sheep Sustainability Framework and contributes to the Pork Sustainability Framework reference group.

Elizabeth's industry roles include non-Executive director of Sheep Producers Australia, member of Western Australian Farmers' Federation Livestock Council, and non-executive director of Agribusiness Australia.

Elizabeth has a long academic career. She is currently an Associate Professor of Supply Chain Management & Logistics at Curtin University. She has worked previously at Newcastle University in the UK as well as the University of London's Royal Veterinary College. Her research interests included food marketing, supply chain management and maritime economics.

Dr Leisa McCarthy

Dr Leisa McCarthy is a Warumungu woman with family ties to the Barkly region, Northern Territory.

Dr McCarthy's formal training is in public health nutrition. She holds a Bachelor of Applied Science Nutrition, a Master of Community Nutrition and her PhD was awarded in 2017. Her thesis investigated household food insecurity in families with young children within an urban setting.

Leisa has also worked in Aboriginal Health for close to 30 years, including 15 years in research. She is the Deputy Director First Nations Engagement and Research Strategy with the Menzies School of Health Research and Executive Director the NT based Top End Aboriginal Health Research Alliance.

Notable roles she has held include Public Health Nutritionist with NT Health and Queensland Health Departments, and an Aboriginal Community Controlled Health Service (ACCHS); jurisdictional Nutrition Policy Officer, NT Department of Health; Research Fellow with an ACCHS and research institute, as well as Senior Researcher and Research Manager roles. Leisa has also held Senior Executive roles within the ACCHS sector.

She has provided representation on several jurisdictional and national committees including the Australian Health Research Alliance and the Northern Territory Remote Stores Program Stakeholder Group. She is a former member of the National Community Controlled Health Organisation Board, the Aboriginal Medical Services Alliance Northern Territory Board and independent member of the former National Public Health Partnership Strategic Intergovernmental Nutrition Alliance.

Claire McClelland

Claire McClelland has served as the Chief Executive Officer of the Australian Fresh Produce Alliance (AFPA) since 2022, leading national advocacy and strategic initiatives to grow Australia's fresh produce sector. Claire is passionate about making sure that Australians can access good quality healthy food and ensuring that the Australian fresh produce sector continues to be world class. Claire is well respected across the horticulture and agriculture sector as a constructive and empowering leader and strong advocate.

Prior to her appointment as CEO, Claire was AFPA's Manager of Communication & Engagement, where she led policy development, industry engagement, and strategic communications initiatives.

Claire has also held senior roles with commercial horticulture producers, AUSVEG and vegetablesWA. Claire brings extensive experience supporting the growth and sustainability of Australia's fresh produce sector.

Su McCluskey

Su McCluskey is a beef cattle farmer near Yass, NSW and a highly experienced senior executive and non-executive director. She has long been an advocate for sustainable agriculture, and was Australia's inaugural Special Representative for Australian Agriculture, working to promote the sector on the international stage.

As the Chair of the Crawford Fund for Food Security, Su is passionate about food and nutrition security and shares a vision of more productive and sustainable agriculture, less poverty and hunger, and a more secure world. Su is a Director of LiveCorp, Interim Chief Executive of the National Farmers' Federation and a Member of the CSIRO Food and Agriculture Advisory Group.

Previously, Su was Commissioner for International Agricultural Research, Commissioner on the National COVID-19 Advisory Board, CEO of the Regional Australia Institute, CEO of the Council of Rural Research and Development Corporations and has held senior positions with the Business Council of Australia, the National Farmers' Federation and the Australian Taxation Office.

Su's experience and expertise includes strong leadership, strategic thinking, financial management, policy, governance, risk, advocacy and analytical skills. Su was named the Westpac/Australian Financial Review Regional Women of Influence in 2013 and the Women in Agribusiness in 2014 for outstanding contribution to policy development.

Pat O'Shannassy

Pat O'Shannassy has vast executive experience in agri-business management, policy, government relations and commodity markets. He has extensive practice in advocacy, trade policy and technical market access.

Pat is the CEO of Grain Trade Australia, which works to ensure the efficient facilitation of commercial activities across the grain supply chain and the President of the International Grain Trade Coalition, which works to promote a rules-based global trading environment for grains, oilseeds, pulses and derived products.

Key strengths include executive management, strategic policy, advocacy, developing trading/risk management strategies, 'hands on' international experience in live & emotive commodity markets, extensive knowledge of derivatives, effective communication, lateral thinking and developing and executing business growth strategies.

David Stout

David Stout draws on more than 32 years' direct retail industry experience, including in key management positions, and has a deep understanding of the food retail sector and associated supply chains.

As chair of the Food and Grocery Sector Group, David was instrumental in bringing together stakeholders across the food supply chain to prepare and respond to all hazards impacting food and grocery supply chains, from natural disasters to biosecurity and cyber security threats.

He is a highly-respected senior executive across a wide range of retail sectors including corporate affairs, operations, customer insights, finance, procurement, risk and regulation, stakeholder engagement, community and supply chain.

David is the Director of Policy, National Retail Association, assisting retailers, government and other stakeholders across issues like trading hours, sustainability, loss prevention and retail crime, leasing, and product safety standards.

Dr Tracy Sullivan

Dr Tracy Sullivan is a widely experienced cattle veterinarian who deeply understands beef production from the paddock to the plate. Her career spans roles as a mixed beef and cereal farmer, veterinary service provider, government regulator, board director and advocate for biosecurity, animal welfare, Indigenous beef production and sustainable agriculture.

Tracy has a PhD in veterinary science, focusing on beef cattle. Tracy was also awarded a 2024 Churchill Fellowship to explore systems and structures that support sustainable Indigenous beef production in New Zealand, the United States and Canada. This Fellowship research demonstrates how Australia can enhance sustainable Indigenous beef production.

Tracy currently serves as an Independent Director at the Yawuru Holdings Company & Primary Partners Pty Ltd, and Director at Australian Veterinary Semen Morphology, Director at the National Farmers Federation and Director at the Australian Veterinary Association.

Terms of Reference

At the first meeting the council agreed the Terms of Reference.

Contact

For any enquiries about the National Food Council contact foodsecurity@aff.gov.au

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/agriculture-land/farm-food-drought/food/national-food-security-strategy/national-food-council>